

Vegetarian/Vegan Diet and Eating Disorders

What is a Vegetarian/Vegan Diet?

A vegetarian diet involves abstaining from the consumption of meat (e.g., red meat, poultry, and seafood) and prioritising foods that come from plants. There are a number of variations of this way of eating - some vegetarians will choose to eat fish, while others follow a vegan diet, and choose not to eat any animal products including eggs, dairy products, honey etc.

Why Do People Adopt a Vegetarian or Vegan Diet?

People may choose to adopt this way of eating for one, several, or all of the following the reasons:

- Religious or cultural beliefs
- Health or dietary concerns
- Taste or sensory preference
- Environmental concerns
- Rejection of the commodity status of animals
- Weight and shape concerns



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Following a vegetarian/vegan diet may contribute to restrictive or controlled eating. Some people find they have a strong aversion to eating meat or animal products and feel unable to include it in their diet. If this sounds familiar, it's important to reflect on your reasons for eating this way. It is also important to assess whether this way of eating began before the onset of your eating disorder, as this can affect your treatment.

Ask yourself:

- Did you stop eating meat or become vegan before or after your eating disorder began?
- Could being vegetarian/vegan be a way to restrict certain foods?

If you're unsure, it might help to talk this through with a therapist. Understanding your motivations can support your recovery.

Alternatively, you may find that you do stand by the values of vegetarianism/veganism, and if this is the case, then it will be important for you to consider how you manage your food intake to ensure a balanced diet that provides the nutrients your body needs.

Note that it may be necessary to suspend a vegetarian or vegan diet during treatment for an eating disorder, in order to facilitate recovery.

Dietary Needs

If continuing with a vegetarian/vegan diet is considered safe by your treatment team, it is essential to work with an experienced dietician to ensure they are getting a healthy balance of nutrients. You will need to ensure adequate intake of protein, vitamin B12, calcium, and iron, as well as less commonly considered nutrients like iodine, selenium, and vitamin D. Most people get the majority of these nutrients from meat and/or animal products, so

ensuring adequate intake from non-meat alternatives requires extra thought and planning.

Vegan diets often require eating larger volumes of food, which can lead to early fullness or discomfort after meals. High fibre intake may also affect digestion and nutrient absorption.

Calcium

If you choose not to eat dairy products, calcium needs to be obtained from alternative sources.

High calcium vegetarian options include:

- Fortified soy milk
- Tofu fortified with calcium

Other sources with smaller amounts of calcium include molasses, almonds, spinach, kale and broccoli. See our handout on [Calcium and Bone Health](#) for more information.



Protein

Since meat is a primary source of protein for many people, vegetarians and vegans need to ensure they consume a wide variety of plant-based foods to meet their protein needs adequately.

- Lentils, legumes, tofu, soy products, dairy, nuts, seeds, whole grains.

Whole grain bread, potatoes, pasta, and corn contribute small amounts of protein. Since plant-based proteins are typically incomplete, it's important to eat a variety of these foods each day to ensure you meet your full protein requirements.

Iron

The nutrient most at risk of deficiency in a vegetarian/vegan diet is iron, as plant-based sources are less effectively absorbed than animal sources. To support iron absorption, pair iron-rich foods with those that enhance absorption and be mindful of foods that inhibit absorption.

- Vegetarian sources include: Legumes, blackstrap molasses, wheatgerm, pasta, bulgur, spinach, prune juice, dried apricots.
- Vitamin C-rich foods (citrus, tomato, broccoli), Vitamin A-rich foods (spreads, oils, full cream dairy) help with absorption
- Foods that inhibit iron absorption include caffeinated drinks, phytates in legumes/grains.

See our handout [All About Iron](#) for more information.

Vitamin B12

Vitamin B12 is essential for nerve function and the production of red blood cells, but it's found almost exclusively in animal-derived foods. Sources of B12 include dairy products (for vegetarians), and fortified foods like soy milk and cereals (for vegans).

See our handout on the [REAL Food Pyramid](#) for more information.

If you are unsure of how to get adequate nutrition through a vegetarian or vegan diet, we suggest speaking to a dietician.